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City Weekly

BOSTON SUNDAY GLOBE SEPTEMBER 15, 2002

ROXBURY

Now, the gentrifiers are black

Out-of-towners add spark, and sparks, to old neighborhood

By Johnny Diaz
GLOBE STAFF

Ken Granderson passionately preaches about the power and perks of the personal computer for low-income communities from his cyber-evangelical pulpit: www.roxbury.com.

Darryl Settles, the brains behind this month's second annual Lower Roxbury/South End Jazz Festival, waxes rhapsodic about the area's jazz heritage and its rich Fort Hill history.

Chenita Daughtry details the quiet comforts of her homey street where she basks in family life after the daily grind as an IBM software engineer.

They all live in Roxbury — and have reinforced and renewed the area's African-American identity, but they have something else in common: They are from somewhere else. Their bounty — the jazz festival, the Web site, or just another new family — is a product of black professionals seeking to renew and strengthen their culture, even if it is not in their old ZIP codes.

Promoters in their own right, they are part of an influx from Brooklyn, Philadelphia, Cincinnati, South Carolina, Louisiana and the Caribbean, bringing new life to Roxbury the way black professionals have in Harlem and communities such as

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GLOBE STAFF PHOTO/BILL GREENE

"You can make change in an area and build on it," says South Carolina native Darryl Settles, now of Roxbury.

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Remembering Tony
Cops and Outlaws pay respects to Eastie power, Anthony Cannata. **Page 8**

After summer...
... comes the time many Bostonians fear most, as officials scramble to set up heating sources for the poor. **Page 3**

Hey, Mr. DJ
The city's low-power radio faces new challenges from its better-connected, higher-wattage rivals. **Page 4**



One day Linda Thomas spotted a mugging taking shape on her street. 'Oh no, not today.' So she did something.



GLOBE STAFF PHOTO/JOSÉ ELEMENT

Linda Thomas, captain of a Ruggles Street Neighborhood Crime Watch group, on her front porch. "We watch out for each other," she says.

A light in the fight against crime

By Michelle Kearns
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

One warm afternoon, Linda Thomas was sweeping her front steps when she spied a backpack-lugging Northeastern student hurrying along the sidewalk. Two kids trailed close behind, their faces obscured by sweatshirt hoods.

As the young man walked faster, the two behind him kept pace. Trying to get away, the young man crossed the street. The hooded followers did, too, passing a pole with a blue "Boston Operation Crime Watch" sign on it. As the student in the backpack tried to escape, the others swore loudly about how they had messed up someone else, messed him up bad.

Would it be a mugging?

Thomas sighed to herself, "Oh no, not today."

She called out to the young man, made up a name, walked toward them.

"John!" she yelled.

Startled, he saw her wink at him.

"How is your mother?" she asked him. He was shaking. His mother was fine, he replied.

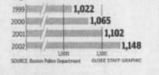
As they chatted, the hoods walked off. With Thomas by his side, the student walked toward the more crowded sidewalks of Columbus Avenue. To Thomas, captain of the Neighborhood Crime Watch group on her block and a CPR trainer with Boston Emergency Services, paying attention to strangers is one of the ways her section of Ruggles Street — one of the more than a third of the blocks in the city with organized crime watches — has become safer with fewer shootings and fewer car break-ins.

"We watch out for each other," said Thomas, winner of a city commendation last month for her work in breaking up the intended street mugging.

For the past decade, the near-doubling of crime watch neighborhoods has been hailed as the city's crime rate has dropped. "I think they're one of the contributing factors, absolutely," said Judith Wright, a civilian community service officer for the

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They're watching out
Number of Boston city blocks with Neighborhood Crime Watches



SOURCE: Boston Police Department
GLOBE STAFF GRAPHIC

JAMAICA PLAIN

Music to repulse loitering teenagers by

At Forest Hills, the T has new tack to extract youths: piped-in Pops

By Shari Rudavsky
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The MBTA has armed the cops at Forest Hills Station with a tool to strike a new note in the battle against youth crime: Boston Pops-style light classical music.

When students congregate each afternoon at the end of the Orange Line, often a time for teen tensions to flare, they're now greeted not just with the shouts of their peers but tunes played by the Pops floating from newly installed speakers.

"We tried arresting the kids last year. That didn't work at all. We just wanted to try something different," said William Fleming, acting chief of the MBTA Police. "If this works, Keith Lockhart has a future in the crime-fighting business."

Forest Hills, through which hundreds of teens stream each day on their way to and from school, sees between two to three fights a day, Fleming said. Two years ago this month, one teen shot another during the morning commute.

Malls and other transit systems, such as Toronto's, have employed similar tactics to dissuade teens from outstaying their welcome in a public space. If the tactic works at Forest Hills, MBTA officials say they will extend it to other stations.

MBTA police decided to try music after noting that few fights broke out after the Pops' Fourth of July concerts. The Pops-style music, they reasoned, might keep youths from tussling, and hasten them toward their destinations.

"That's what we're looking for — for people to get along and get along," said Detective Peter Pacciocco. "You don't want to drive them out, but if it's not music they like, they may go somewhere they can listen to music they do like."

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GLOBE PHOTO/AMY NEWMAN

Carlos Lopez, and friends Calvin Diaz, (back to camera) and Austin Castro, all 16, hanging out recently at Forest Hills station. "This is crazy," said Lopez of the classical music the T is piping in. "Makes you want to go to sleep."

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